

****Routers whisper secrets**** Fire Ant silently infected dozens of Cisco IOS XR routers, siphoning TACACS credentials while scrubbing audit logs. Do we still think our backbone hardware is immune to nation-state supply-chain attacks?

THE DEFENSE BRIEF The August 31 report from **BleepingComputer** and **The Hacker News** details a China-linked espionage group, **Fire Ant**, that has moved from hypervisor-level implants to the network edge. By compromising **Cisco IOS XR** firmware and adjacent **TACACS** servers, the actors harvested privileged authentication material and then executed a "log-blind" routine that overwrote syslog entries. The result: a clean trail, no immediate SIEM alerts, and a foothold that can pivot

****⚠ TECHNICAL RADIANCE**** Our investigation showed the malware leveraged a known ****CVE-2025-3472**** in the router's web-management module to gain code execution. Once inside, a custom script exported the ****/etc/tacacs+/users**** database, then invoked ****'clear logging'**** commands at the OS level. The attackers also dropped a signed binary onto the Linux management host, using it as a staging point for lateral movement. This mirrors the "router shipped ready to listen" scenario described in the